Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Z

Zadok

Zadok was a key figure in the history of Israel's priesthood. He first appears in the story of 2 Samuel (2 Samuel 8:17). Some scholars think he might not have been born into a priestly family. However, the Bible states he was a descendant of Aaron (1 Chronicles 6:1–15, 50–53). Zadok's family line traces back to Eleazar, Aaron's son (1 Chronicles 6:4–8; 24:3; Ezra 7:2–5). Zadok served with Abiathar, a descendant of Eli. Both were priests of Israel under King David (2 Samuel 8:17; 20:25).

When Absalom rebelled against King David, both Zadok and Abiathar proved their loyalty by bringing the Ark to him, ready to join him in exile (2 Samuel 15:24–29). However, David sent them back to Jerusalem to act as his spies.

Later, David's son Adonijah tried to take David's throne with Joab and Abiathar's help. Zadok wisely chose not to support him (1 Kings 1:5–10). Abiathar was banished (1 Kings 2:26–27), fulfilling the prophecy that Eli's family would lose the priesthood (1 Samuel 2:27–36). In this prophecy, God said, "I will raise up for Myself a faithful priest. He will do whatever is in My heart and mind. And I will build for him an enduring house, and he will walk before My anointed one for all time" (1 Samuel 2:35).

Zadok fulfilled the prophecy and became the only high priest under Solomon (1 Kings 2:35). Zadok's descendants served as Israel's priests during the monarchy and beyond. Azariah, the chief priest during Hezekiah's reign, was from Zadok's line (2 Chronicles 31:10). During the exile to Babylon, Ezekiel's vision of the new temple mentions Zadok's priestly line (Ezekiel 40:46; 43:19; 44:15; 48:11). In the early 100s BC, when the Jews were under Seleucid rule, the high priesthood became a political position and was taken from Zadok's descendants. Because of Ezekiel's prophecies, Jewish groups, like those who created the Dead Sea Scrolls, continued to hope for the return of Zadok's line to the high priesthood. The New Testament states that Jesus Christ now holds the office of the high priest (Hebrews 9:11; 10:12–25).

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 8:17; 15:23–37; 1 Kings 1:5–53; 2:35; 1 Chronicles 6:1–15, 50–53; Ezra 7:2; Ezekiel 40:46; 43:19; 44:15; 48:11

Zerubbabel

Zerubbabel was a Jew born in Babylon. He moved to Judea in 538 BC as the governor of Jerusalem under Persian rule. Cyrus, the king of Persia, allowed Jews who were captured and exiled from Judah to return home. Zerubbabel led one of the first groups of these returning exiles.

Zerubbabel arrived in Judea to rebuild the temple, starting with the altar. Sacrifices could resume once the Holy Place was ready. However, local opposition halted construction. The Judeans lost focus until Haggai and Zechariah's preaching motivated them to restart. Zerubbabel played a key role in leading and organizing the rebuilding, which took about six years, from 520 to 515 BC.

Many people expected great things from Zerubbabel because he was from King David's family (1 Chronicles 3:1–19). Zechariah and Haggai describe Zerubbabel in messianic terms as the one chosen by God to restore Israel (Haggai 2:21–23; Zechariah 4:6–7). However, Zerubbabel soon disappears from the biblical story without explanation. This early governor of Judea was not the Messiah. Instead, Jesus Christ, one of Zerubbabel's descendants, would take on that glorious role (Matthew 1:12).

Passages for Further Study

Ezra 2:1–6:22; Nehemiah 7:7; Haggai 1:12–2:23; Zechariah 4:1–14; Matthew 1:12